



number—far from ending difference as it claims (*na jaat paat, na bhed bhav*), it merely institutes a new set of differences—a mobile phone number, a particular company's mobile phone number.

From what the dictionary says, religion is “a set of beliefs concerning the cause, nature, and purpose of the universe, especially when considered as the creation of a super-human agency or agencies, usually involving devotional and ritual observances, and often containing a moral code governing the conduct of human affairs.” So why should the state, which is about the political organisation of human societies, have anything to do with it? The trick, of course, lies in that bit about “ritual observances” and “moral code.” No religion is a religion unless there is more than one individual following those ritual observances and that moral code. There has to be some way of ensuring observance. This requires an internal policing mechanism. Since there is more than one religious community in all modern societies today, the observances and moral code

of one may impinge on those of another. And since all religious communities today have long histories of conflict with other religious communities, every moment of the present is already loaded with buttons that go straight to that history. Click. Replay.

So if any degree of order is to be maintained in society, this

means an external policing mechanism. Religious communities have institutions that own property and control resources. In addition in India, the laws of the religious community into which you are born determine how family property will be inherited—which needs both internal and external policing mechanisms. Internal policing mechanisms can be institutions like caste panchayats. But more often, policing is all-pervasive and amorphous, conducted typically through families. The external policing mechanism is the state. What distinguishes it from other institutions is that it has a monopoly over legitimate means of coercion. It can force you to pay taxes and prevent you from avenging the murder of a loved one. This state is not located above all religious conflict. It is by no means a neutral umpire. So its policing is meant to achieve specific results, depending on what political capital is at stake.

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IS THE NUMBER OF
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This means, paradoxically, that the state is continuously engaging with religion. While French democracy enshrines the abstract citizen at its centre, most non-Western democracies have intertwined group identity with individual citizenship. Your Indian identity is shot through with your regional, caste, religious and linguistic loyalties. The right to wear a turban or a head-scarf to school is in fact precisely the test of secularism in India. The French state thinks like the young sarpanch—eliminate the public expression of difference, and you eliminate conflict. But of course, as French suburbs burnt in November 2005, in violence that combined two challenges to abstract citizenship, race and religion, it was the violent imperialist history of France that stalked the streets.

Conflict is not produced by difference, it is the failure to acknowledge difference, especially difference arising from a history of unequal power relations. Take that phone

Narrow escape: A family runs for cover during the July Indore riots